Your Father's Care Isn't Working: Three Things to Do Before the Next Family Call

Three first moves, in order, and the arguments that can wait.

Your father's care isn't working, and every call about it tries to cover ten problems at once. Your sister does most of the day-to-day and is worn out, and nobody can say exactly what is going wrong.

Start here. Three things, in this order, before the family talks again.

1 Write down what isn't getting done

List the tasks that are slipping and the decisions coming up, one line each, with an example and a day where you have one: “He missed his Tuesday appointment and no one knew until Thursday.” Write what happened and leave out whose fault it was. Don't try to solve anything yet. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Until the problems are on paper, every call starts again from the beginning.

2 Ask your sister what can't go on as it is

Find ten minutes with her on her own, before the family call, and ask one question: what has to change right away? Then mostly listen, and write her answer down in her words. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST She carries most of the week, so her answer holds things the rest of the family can't see from where they sit.

3 Mark what belongs with a professional

Go down your list and put a mark beside anything about your father's health or his medications. Those lines go to his doctor's office, the nurse or the pharmacist, written down with the example. The family doesn't have to settle them, and shouldn't try. [3] [4]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST It takes those questions off the family's table, so the call can be about the things only the family can sort out.

What can wait for a later conversation

The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one meeting, and that more meetings help. So these can sit on the list for now: [1]

- Whose fault any of it is.
- Settling whether your father should move, or should have more help than he has now. For now, note who thinks what.
- Who in the family does what in the long run.
- Disagreements between brothers and sisters that are older than this one.
- What it all adds up to. That takes people who assess your father, and your list is what you bring them.

One thing that isn't for the family call

A concern about your father's health doesn't need the family's agreement first. The National Institute on Aging says that if you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health, suggest a visit to a health care provider. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say who is right, whether your father is safe, or what care he needs. It puts the days before the next family call in order.

Ready for the next step?

You have a list of what's slipping, your sister's answer in her own words, and a mark beside what belongs with a professional. The care interview takes it from there: it asks about your father's daily life and the care around him in a set order, including the parts nobody has complained about yet, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Listing the problems before trying to solve them, and not expecting one meeting to cover everything, follow the Family Caregiver Alliance. Asking the primary caregiver what would help, taking health concerns to a health care provider and bringing a written list to the doctor follow the National Institute on Aging. The order is ours.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
3. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
4. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers

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